

Word family: **penalty / penalties / penal / penalise / penalize / penalised / penalized / penalising / penalizing / penalisation / penalization**

Base word: penalty

Plural: penalties

Related forms: penal, penalise/penalize, penalisation/penalization

Part of speech: noun (名詞)

Related adjective/verb: penal (形容詞) , penalise/penalize (動詞)

Your sentence:

> “...such lost business is not a minor inconvenience but a real financial **penalty**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **penalty** means a **significant financial disadvantage, cost, or loss that someone suffers because of a situation**.

Importantly, the restaurant is **not being officially fined**. The writer means that long-stay customers effectively impose an economic cost on the business through lost sales.

繁體中文： **經濟代價；財務損失；因某種情況而承受的不利後果**

中文翻譯：

> “...not a minor inconvenience but a real financial **penalty**.”

「.....這不只是小小的不便，而是實際的**經濟代價 / 財務損失**。」

Here:

financial penalty = 因某種情況而實際承受的金錢損失或經濟不利，不一定是官方罰款

1. **penalty = punishment for breaking a law or rule (懲罰) — 處罰；刑罰；懲罰**

This is the central formal meaning.

Meaning: A punishment imposed because someone has broken a law, rule, agreement, or requirement.

Practice 1

> “The offence carries a severe **penalty**.”

「這項罪行可招致嚴厲的**刑罰 / 處罰**。」

Practice 2

> “Anyone who breaks the rule may face a **penalty**.”

「任何違反規則的人都可能受到**處罰**。」

****penalty = 因違法、違規或違反要求而被正式施加的不利後果****

Common:

- * severe penalty
- * legal penalty
- * criminal penalty
- * maximum penalty
- * impose a penalty
- * face a penalty

2. ****penalty = monetary charge/fine imposed for breaking a rule or condition (金錢) — 罰款 ; 罰金 ; 違約罰款****

A very common form of penalty is financial.

Practice 3

> “There is a **penalty** for late payment.”

「逾期付款會被收取**罰款 / 附加罰款**。」

Practice 4

> “The company was required to pay a financial **penalty**.”

「公司被要求繳付一筆**罰款**。」

****penalty = 因違反規則、付款期限、合約條款等而被額外收取的金錢****

Common:

- * late-payment penalty
- * tax penalty
- * financial penalty
- * contractual penalty

For strict semantic counting, this belongs to Meaning 1: the punishment happens to be monetary.

3. **penalty = extra charge for doing something earlier/later or contrary to agreed terms (收費)
— 額外費用；罰款性收費**

Not every financial **penalty** comes from illegal conduct.

For example:

* early repayment penalty

* withdrawal penalty

* cancellation penalty

* late-return penalty

Practice 5

> “You may have to pay an early-withdrawal **penalty**.”

「你可能需要支付提前提款的**罰款性費用 / 附加費**。」

Practice 6

> “The contract includes a cancellation **penalty**.”

「合約包含取消服務的**罰款 / 違約費用**。」

Here, the idea is:

> **you chose or failed to act in a way specified by an agreement, so an additional cost applies**

This is still part of the formal-sanction branch.

4. **penalty = disadvantage, cost, or loss caused by a situation (不利後果) — 代價；損失；不利影響**

This is the **exact branch in your passage**.

It does **not** require a law, authority, or official punishment.

Practice 7 — Original

> “Long-stay customers impose a financial **penalty** on the restaurant.”

「長時間逗留的顧客令餐廳承受實際的**經濟損失 / 財務代價**。」

Practice 8

> “Small firms sometimes suffer a cost **penalty** because they cannot buy in bulk.”

「小型企業有時因無法大量採購而承受較高成本的**劣勢**。」

Practice 9

> “Poor insulation creates an energy **penalty**.”

「隔熱不良會造成額外能源消耗的**代價**。」

penalty = 某種選擇、設計、條件或情況造成的額外成本、損失或競爭劣勢

This is a major figurative extension.

5. **penalty** = negative trade-off for gaining some other benefit (權衡) — 代價；犧牲

In technical, business, and analytical writing, **penalty** often means a drawback accompanying some benefit.

Practice 10

> “The stronger material comes with a weight **penalty**.”

「更堅固的材料同時帶來重量增加的**代價**。」

Practice 11

> “Extra security may involve a performance **penalty**.”

「加強安全性可能會帶來效能下降的**代價**。」

penalty = 為取得某項優點而必須承受的額外成本 / 性能下降 / 其他不利結果

This belongs to Meaning 4.

6. **penalty** = sports punishment for a foul or rule violation (體育) — 判罰；處罰

In sport, a **penalty** is a sanction imposed when a player or team breaks a rule.

Practice 12

> “The referee awarded a **penalty**.”

「球證判了一個**十二碼 / 罰球**。」

Practice 13

> “The team received a five-yard **penalty**.”

「該隊被判**後退五碼的處罰**。」

The exact form depends on the sport.

Possible consequences include:

- * loss of distance
- * free kick
- * penalty kick
- * penalty shot
- * time in a penalty box
- * penalty points

This is a major domain-specific sense.

7. **penalty kick** = football/soccer spot kick (足球) — 十二碼 ; 點球

A **penalty kick** is awarded after certain fouls committed in the penalty area.

Practice 14

> “She scored from a **penalty**.”

「她主射**十二碼 / 點球**得分。」

In football usage, bare:

> **a penalty**

can itself mean:

> ****a penalty kick****

This is lexicalized enough that learners should recognize it.

8. ****penalty shoot-out = penalty-kick tiebreaker (足球) — 十二碼互射；點球大戰****

Practice 15

> “The match was decided by a ****penalty shoot-out****.”

「比賽由****十二碼互射 / 點球大戰****決定勝負。」

This is a fixed sports compound, not a separate core meaning.

9. ****penalty shot = awarded shot in certain sports (體育) — 罰球****

In sports such as ice hockey, a ****penalty shot**** is a special scoring attempt awarded after certain violations.

The exact rules vary by sport.

Again, this belongs under Meaning 6.

10. ****penalty box = area where penalized players wait (冰球等) — 受罰席；罰球區****

A player may be sent to the ****penalty box**** for a specified period.

This is another fixed sports compound under the sanction branch.

11. ****penalty points = points added/deducted as punishment (扣分 / 罰分) — 罰分；違例記分****

Depending on the system, ****penalty points**** may refer to:

- * sporting penalties;
- * points recorded against a driving licence;
- * scoring deductions in competitions.

Practice 16

> “Drivers can receive **penalty points** for certain offences.”

「駕駛者因某些違例行為可能被記**違例駕駛記分 / 罰分**。」

This is an important fixed compound.

12. **death penalty = punishment of execution (法律) — 死刑**

Practice 17

> “The **death penalty** is a form of criminal punishment.”

「**死刑**是一種刑事刑罰。」

death penalty = 由國家法律制度規定，以處決作為刑罰

This is a fixed legal expression under Meaning 1.

13. **under penalty of something = with a specified punishment if one fails to comply (正式) — 違者將受.....處罰**

A formal construction:

> “Disclosure is prohibited under penalty of law.”

Approximately:

「不得披露，**違者依法受罰**。」

More naturally in many modern contexts:

> subject to a penalty

This construction is formal and not especially common in everyday conversation.

14. **penalty clause = contractual provision specifying consequences of breach (合約) — 違約罰則條款**

In contract-related language, a **penalty clause** sets out a financial or other consequence for breach.

Practice 18

> “The agreement contains a **penalty clause** for late completion.”

「合約載有延遲完成的**違約罰則條款**。」

Legal treatment of such clauses differs by jurisdiction, so learners should not assume that every stated contractual penalty is automatically enforceable.

15. **penalty** = added cost in optimization/mathematics/statistics (數學 / 數據科學) — 懲罰項 ; 罰函數

In mathematics, statistics, machine learning, and optimization, a **penalty** is an added cost used to discourage undesirable solutions or excessive complexity.

Examples:

- * penalty term
- * penalty function
- * regularization penalty

Practice 19

> “The model adds a **penalty** for excessive complexity.”

「這個模型會對過度複雜加入一個**懲罰項**。」

penalty = 在目標函數中加入的額外成本，使某些結果變得較不理想

This is a genuine modern technical sense.

16. **performance penalty** = reduction in speed/efficiency (科技) — 效能代價 ; 性能損失

Very common in computing and engineering.

Practice 20

> “Encryption can introduce a small performance **penalty**.”

「加密可能會帶來輕微的**效能損失 / 性能代價**。」

This is not a punishment at all.

It is the figurative **cost/disadvantage** sense from Meaning 4.

Related form: **penalise / penalize**

Penalise (BrE) / **penalize** (AmE) means:

> to punish someone or put them at a disadvantage.

It has two important branches.

penalise = officially punish

Practice 21

> “Players are **penalised** for breaking the rules.”

「球員違規會受到**處罰**。」

penalise = put at a disadvantage

Practice 22

> “The system should not **penalise** small businesses.”

「這個制度不應令小型企業**處於不利地位 / 承受額外代價**。」

The second is especially important because it mirrors the passage sense of **penalty**.

Related form: **penal**

Penal means relating to punishment, especially punishment under criminal law or systems of imprisonment.

Common:

* penal system

* penal code

* penal institution

* penal reform

Practice 23

> “The country revised parts of its **penal code**.”

「該國修訂了部分**刑法典**。」

penal = 與刑罰、刑事處罰或監禁制度有關的

This word is much narrower than **penalty**.

You would not normally say:

> “a penal cost” ❌

for the passage meaning.

Related form: **penalisation / penalization**

This means:

> the act/process of penalising someone or something.

Examples:

* penalization for late submission

* penalisation of inefficient designs

Useful in formal or technical contexts, but considerably less frequent than **penalty** and **penalise**.

Important distinction: **penalty vs punishment**

punishment

is the broad concept of making someone suffer a consequence for wrongdoing.

penalty

often means a **specific officially defined consequence** for breaking a rule or law.

- > punishment for bad behaviour
- > a penalty for late payment

But **penalty** also has the broader “disadvantage/cost” sense that **punishment** usually lacks.

In your passage:

- > financial penalty

does **not** mean literal punishment.

Important distinction: **penalty vs fine**

fine

specifically means a sum of money officially imposed as punishment.

penalty

is broader and may be:

- * a fine;
- * imprisonment;
- * loss of points;
- * sporting sanction;
- * contractual charge;
- * general disadvantage.

So:

- > every fine is a type of penalty,

but not every penalty is a fine.

Important distinction: **penalty vs fee**

fee

is normally a neutral charge for a service or transaction.

penalty

is an additional negative consequence because of some action, breach, delay, or condition.

- > application fee
- > late-payment penalty

Important distinction: **penalty vs cost**

cost

is neutral: something requires money, resources, time, etc.

penalty

often suggests an **extra or undesirable cost caused by a particular condition or choice**.

Compare:

- > "The equipment costs \$1,000."

versus:

- > "Its heavy design carries a fuel-efficiency penalty."

The second means a disadvantage caused by the design.

Important distinction: **penalty vs consequence**

consequence

is neutral and can be good or bad.

penalty

is inherently negative.

- > consequence of a decision
- > penalty for a mistake

Important distinction: **penalty vs sanction**

sanction

in legal/regulatory contexts can mean an official punitive measure.

penalty

is often the actual consequence imposed.

Depending on context:

> sanctions

may include:

- * fines
- * restrictions
- * suspensions
- * other penalties

They overlap but are not identical.

Important distinction: **penalty vs disadvantage**

This matters for your passage.

disadvantage

= any unfavorable condition.

penalty

= a disadvantage that functions like a cost imposed by some condition, choice, or arrangement.

So:

> financial disadvantage

is neutral description.

> financial penalty

more strongly suggests:

> **this situation makes someone pay a price for it**

even without formal punishment.

Grammar note: **penalty for**

Very common:

- > penalty for late payment
- > penalty for breaking the rule
- > penalty for cancellation

penalty for + action/offence

= 因.....而受到的處罰 / 代價

Grammar note: **penalty on**

When focusing on who bears the negative consequence:

- > impose a penalty on a company

= 對公司施加處罰。

But in figurative writing:

- > place a financial penalty on small businesses

can also mean:

- > 令小型企業承受財務劣勢。

Grammar note: **carry a penalty**

A law/offence can:

- > **carry a maximum penalty of...**

meaning:

- > potentially result in that punishment.

Example:

> “The offence carries a heavy penalty.”

「該罪行可被判處嚴厲刑罰。」

Grammar note: ****pay/incur a penalty****

****pay a penalty****

usually financial:

> pay a late-payment penalty

****incur a penalty****

more formal and broader:

> incur a tax penalty

> incur penalty points

Countability note

****Penalty**** is usually countable when referring to individual sanctions:

> a penalty

> several penalties

But it can appear as a modifying noun in compounds:

* penalty charge

* penalty rate

* penalty point

* penalty clause

Family-extension note

The practical family includes:

* **penalty**
 * **penalties**
 * **penal**
 * **penalise / penalize**
 * **penalised / penalized**
 * **penalising / penalizing**
 * **penalisation / penalization**

The broad semantic network has two major concepts:

1. **an officially imposed punishment for violating a rule**
2. **a negative cost/disadvantage that functions like a price paid for some condition or choice**

From #1 come:

* legal penalties
 * fines
 * tax penalties
 * sporting penalties
 * death penalty
 * penalty points

From #2 come:

* financial penalty in your passage
 * weight penalty
 * energy penalty
 * performance penalty

Technical mathematical **penalty terms/functions** metaphorically recreate the same idea: make an undesirable choice “cost more.”

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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penalty — formal punishment	因違法、違規或違反要求而正式施加的處罰 / 刑罰
financial penalty — fine	因違規、遲交、違約等而被額外收取的罰款 / 罰金
penalty — disadvantage/cost	某種條件、選擇或安排造成的額外損失、代價或不利影響
sports penalty	運動員 / 球隊違規後受到的判罰
a penalty — football	足球中可指十二碼 / 點球
death penalty	死刑
penalty points	因違規而記錄 / 扣除的罰分或違例記分
penalty clause	合約中規定違約後果的罰則條款
penalty — maths/ML	為抑制不理想結果而加入目標函數的懲罰項 / 額外成本

performance penalty	某項設計或功能造成的效能損失 / 性能代價	
penalise / penalize	正式處罰；或令某人 / 某事處於不利地位	
penal	與刑罰、刑事處罰或監禁制度有關的	

For your original sentence

> "...such lost business is not a minor inconvenience but a real financial ****penalty****."

The exact meaning is:

****penalty = 長時間佔用餐桌令餐廳少接待其他顧客，因此實際承受的收入損失和經濟代價****

So:

> ****a real financial penalty****

= ****實際而明顯的財務損失 / 經濟代價****

It would be misleading to translate this automatically as:

> ****罰款**** ❌

because nobody is formally fining the restaurant.

The sentence uses ****penalty**** figuratively:

> ****the business is effectively "paying a price" for someone else's behaviour.****

For your database, I would count ****3 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****penalty****:

1. ****official punishment or sanction for breaking a law, rule, or condition****
2. ****negative cost, disadvantage, or loss caused by a situation or choice****
3. ****sports sanction, including lexicalized uses such as a penalty kick/shot****

I would keep ****fines, late-payment penalties, tax penalties, death penalty, penalty points**** under #1; ****financial/performance/weight/energy penalties**** under #2; and retain mathematical/statistical ****penalty term/function**** as an important technical extension rather than creating an unnecessarily separate everyday core.